

Module 5: Climate Change and Migration

Signature Learning Experience

Purpose

Climate migration is a future-facing problem, so this assignment teaches a future-facing method: structured scenario planning. Teams build plausible scenarios for climate-related migration in one region and stress-test current policy against them — learning to reason under uncertainty without sliding into either denial or doom.

Aligned learning outcomes

- Describe climate migration dynamics for a specific region (UG 1)
- Identify causes distinguishing slow-onset and rapid-onset displacement (UG 2)
- Explain the legal gaps facing people displaced by climate (UG 3)
- Recognize global impacts through concrete regional analysis (UG 4)

Graduate extension

Graduate students build the scenario matrix formally (two critical uncertainties, four scenarios), ground each scenario in published projections (IPCC, Groundswell), and write the policy stress-test as a standalone briefing note (Grad 1–2).

Assignment steps

1. In teams of 3–4, choose a region: Central American dry corridor, Sahel, coastal Bangladesh, Pacific island states, or a US region (Gulf Coast, Southwest heat belt).
2. Research the region's climate exposure, current mobility patterns, and adaptation capacity using IPCC summaries, the World Bank Groundswell report, and IOM/UNHCR sources.
3. Identify the two most consequential uncertainties (e.g., pace of warming, adaptation investment) and sketch 3–4 distinct, plausible scenarios — label clearly what is projection and what is reasoned speculation.
4. For each scenario, describe the mobility outcome: who moves, where, when — and who cannot move (immobility is an outcome too).
5. Stress-test at least two existing policy instruments against each scenario: where do they hold, where do they fail, what legal gap is exposed?
6. Present the scenarios as a team; submit the written exercise individually.

Deliverables & format

- Team scenario presentation (10 minutes) with a one-page scenario matrix handout
- Individual written analysis, 1,200–1,500 words, covering one scenario in depth and the policy stress-test (graduate: full briefing-note format, 2,000+)
- Source list distinguishing data, projection, and informed speculation

Grading rubric

Each criterion is scored at one of four levels, then weighted as shown. The overall grade is the weighted combination of criterion scores. Instructors may adapt weights and descriptors to local requirements.

Criterion (weight)	Exemplary (A)	Proficient (B)	Developing (C)	Beginning (D–F)
Evidentiary grounding — projections traced to sources 30%	Evidence and accuracy are exemplary: evidentiary grounding — projections traced to sources is met with high-quality, correctly cited sources for every substantive claim; terms, facts, and frameworks are used precisely.	Evidence and accuracy are solid: evidentiary grounding — projections traced to sources is met for nearly all claims, with only minor sourcing gaps or imprecisions that do not affect conclusions.	Evidence and accuracy are uneven: evidentiary grounding — projections traced to sources is partly met — some claims lack support, sources are thin or misread, or terms are used loosely in ways that weaken conclusions.	Evidence and accuracy are deficient: evidentiary grounding — projections traced to sources is not met; key claims are unsupported or wrong, and errors undermine the work's conclusions.
Plausibility and distinctness of scenarios 20%	Method is rigorous and transparent: plausibility and distinctness of scenarios is fully documented, choices are justified, limitations are stated, and another student could replicate the work from what is written.	Method is sound: plausibility and distinctness of scenarios is documented and mostly justified, with limitations acknowledged; small gaps would not change the findings.	Method is partial: plausibility and distinctness of scenarios is described but under-documented or inconsistently applied, leaving findings plausible but not checkable.	Method is absent or unsound: plausibility and distinctness of scenarios is missing, undocumented, or applied so loosely that the findings cannot be trusted.
Quality of the policy stress-test and legal-gap analysis 30%	Analysis is genuinely insightful: quality of the policy stress-test and legal-gap analysis goes beyond summary to produce non-obvious, well-defended conclusions; concepts are applied accurately, complexity is preserved, and counterpoints are engaged seriously.	Analysis is competent: quality of the policy stress-test and legal-gap analysis is achieved with clear reasoning and accurate use of course concepts, though conclusions stay near the expected.	Analysis is thin: quality of the policy stress-test and legal-gap analysis is attempted but leans on summary or assertion; concepts are named more than used, and complications are avoided.	Analysis is absent: quality of the policy stress-test and legal-gap analysis is not achieved; the work describes without analyzing or draws conclusions its own material does not support.

Criterion (weight)	Exemplary (A)	Proficient (B)	Developing (C)	Beginning (D–F)
Team presentation and individual writing 20%	Communication is publication-ready: team presentation and individual writing is achieved with precise, well-organized prose, correct citation, and figures or formats that make the argument easier to grasp.	Communication is clear and professional: team presentation and individual writing is achieved with minor lapses in polish, organization, or citation that never obscure meaning.	Communication is understandable but rough: team presentation and individual writing is only partly achieved — disorganization, citation errors, or unclear figures make the reader work to follow the argument.	Communication impedes the work: team presentation and individual writing is not achieved; errors, disorganization, or missing citations obscure the substance.